

the training director, Al Levy (since retired), told me he'd once made a tape on what to tell a client after a loss. This I could probably reproduce myself, though I wish I'd been able to hear his version.

I have broker's school to thank for Useful Tip Number 17:

The newer the broker, the less likely he'll make a spontaneous remark

For several years, there's been a trend toward more and more prepared answers, and more dialogues that cover every conceivable investment situation. In fact, while the other trainees were studying, I experimented with adding the Merrill Lynch lines to some of the famous laments in literary history. Among the many scripts, I found a Merrill Lynch solution to every conceivable dilemma:

ELECTRA: Hades, Persephone, Hermes steward of death, Eternal Wrath and Furies, Children of gods who see all murders and all adulterous thieves, come soon, I have no strength, I cannot stand alone under this load of my affliction.

MERRILL LYNCH: I understand how you FEEL [*Indicating empathy*], other people have FELT that way [*Indicating the prospect is not alone*], and they have FOUND that there are a number of investment vehicles that offer considerable stability.

SOCRATES: Do you really think that anyone, knowing the bad things to be bad, still desires them?

MERRILL LYNCH: Many investors rate the need for a broker who cares for their clients as one of their highest needs. What are your expectations?

SOCRATES: Do those who think that the bad things benefit know that the bad things are bad?

MERRILL LYNCH: Due to the size and depth of our organization, we're frequently in a position to offer clients opportunities they may not have access to through their regular investment channels.